

DECODED EXPLAINED

17th June, 2026

Gallant IAS Daily Current Affairs Initiative

IORA : Canada's Observer Application

IORA examining Canada's request to be observer

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Canada's application to become an observer in the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) "is being examined" at the 28th meeting of the Committee of Senior Officials being held in New Delhi, Sanjiv Ranjan, IORA's Secretary-General, told *The Hindu* on Monday.

"Canada has made an application to become a dialogue partner of the organisation, and it is being examined at this meeting," he said.

Mr. Ranjan added member states could benefit from Canada's potential inclusion into the fold considering its expertise in varied maritime domains.

"They [Canada] are a big maritime power because of the huge coastal zones they have, they also have various initiatives and expertise in maritime safety, security and connectivity, among other areas, which would be of help to other member states of the organisation," he said.



Sanjiv Ranjan

Mr. Ranjan welcomed the potential peace deal between Iran and the U.S. that could end more than 100 days of hostilities in the Strait of Hormuz.

"It is a welcome thing that we may have an agreement by the end of this week as has been reported," he said.

Listing out priorities in the Indian Ocean, Mr. Ranjan said disaster response and mitigation remain a priority for IORA. He said the adverse impact of climate change would be "disproportionate" in the Indian Ocean. "Therefore, we must be ready in dealing with that," he said.

IORA and Canada's Observer Status Bid

• What is IORA?

Indian Ocean Rim Association an **intergovernmental organisation** for regional cooperation. Its vision originated during a visit by **Nelson Mandela to India in 1995.**

- Established in **1997; headquartered in Ebène, Mauritius.**
- 23 member states + 10 dialogue partners; **India is a founding member.**
- Focus areas: **maritime safety, trade, disaster risk management, fisheries, tourism.**

• Canada's Application

- **Canada has applied to become a dialogue partner (observer) in IORA.**
- Application being examined at the 28th meeting of the Committee of Senior Officials, New Delhi.
- Canada cited for expertise in maritime safety, security, and connectivity.

• Strategic Dimensions

- IORA priorities include **disaster response, climate change mitigation, and Indian Ocean security.**
- Secretary-General noted climate change impact will be 'disproportionate' in the Indian Ocean.
- The Strait of Hormuz hostility (Iran-US) also flagged as a concern for Indian Ocean stability.
- Canada's entry could expand IORA's global maritime expertise base.

IORA and Canada's Observer Status Bid

IORA Council of Ministers:

Highest decision making body comprised of the **Minister of Foreign Affairs (or equivalent)** of all Member States which meets annually.

Troika:

An institutional mechanism consisting of the current **Chair, Vice-Chair, which is the future chair, and past Chair (referred to as previous chair in the Charter)** of the IORA.

Indian Ocean Dialogue (IOD):

A Track 1.5 forum launched in 2013, encouraging open dialogue among member states, on key strategic issues in the Indian Ocean Region.

IORA Sustainable Development Program (ISDP):

Introduced in 2014 for the least developed countries (LDCs) that require assistance and support to conduct projects.

IORA and Canada's Observer Status Bid

Indian Ocean transports **75% of global trade and 50% of daily oil consumption**

While aligning IORA's goals with India's **SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region) vision**, India can utilize its chairmanship to promote regional stability and development.

IORA Countries



Members of IORA

Africa: South Africa + Mozambique + Tanzania + Kenya + Somalia

Indian Ocean: Comoros + Seychelles + Mauritius + Madagascar + France + Maldives

Gulf : Yemen + Oman + UAE + Iran

South Asia : India + Sri Lanka + Bangladesh

South East Asia : Thailand + Indonesia + Malaysia + Singapore + Australia

Practice Question

Q.With reference to 'Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation (IOR-ARC), consider the following statements: (2015)

1. It was established very recently in response to incidents of piracy and accidents of oil spills.
2. It is an alliance meant for maritime security only.

Which of the statements given above is/ are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Practice Question

Q. Which of the following are the members of Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA)?:

1. Myanmar

2. India

3. Pakistan

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

[A] 1 and 3 only

[B] 2 only

[C] 2 and 3 only

[D] 1, 2 and 3

Exercise Pitch Black 2026

Air Force to take part in 'Exercise Pitch Black'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indian Air Force (IAF) will participate in Exercise Pitch Black 2026, the Royal Australian Air Force's (RAAF) premier multinational air combat exercise, scheduled to be held in Australia's Northern Territory from July 20 to August.

Australian High Commissioner to India Philip Green OAM announced India's participation on X on Tuesday, tagging the IAF's official handle and citing the exercise as an opportunity to strengthen regional interoperability across the Indo-Pacific.

According to the Australian Defence Ministry, the exercise will bring together more than 100 aircraft and personnel from 19 allied and partner nations, providing a platform for participating air forces to enhance operational interoperability, strengthen military cooperation, and refine air combat tactics. Exercise Pitch Black is the RAAF's largest international exercise.

Exercise Pitch Black 2026

• What is Exercise Pitch Black?

- Biennial multinational air combat exercise hosted by the Royal Australian Air Force (RAAF).
- Held over Australia's Northern Territory; RAAF's largest international exercise.
- Exercise Pitch Black 2026 scheduled: July 20 to August 2026.
- Brings together over 100 aircraft and personnel from 19 allied and partner nations.

• India's Participation

- Indian Air Force (IAF) will participate in Exercise Pitch Black 2026.
- Announced by the Australian High Commissioner to India, Philip Green OAM.
- Objective: strengthen regional interoperability across the Indo-Pacific.

Tenth Schedule : Party Mergers & Anti-Defection

What does Tenth Schedule provide on party mergers?

Why has the misuse of the merger provision increased after the deletion of paragraph 3?

LETTER AND SPIRIT

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

As many as 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs met the Lok Sabha Speaker and announced their decision to merge with Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI). This has raised issues about the interpretation of Tenth Schedule with respect to merger of political parties.

What is the origin of Tenth Schedule?

The defections of legislators during 1960s and 70s from their parent parties created political instability in many States bringing down elected governments. This prompted the 52nd constitutional amendment to introduce the 'anti-defection' law through the Tenth Schedule in 1985. This Schedule provides

that a member of a House of Parliament or State legislature who voluntarily gives up the membership of their 'political party' or votes against the instructions of their party in a House are liable for disqualification from such House. The 'political party' is the entire organisation of a party, while the 'legislature party' is all the members of a political party in a House of Parliament or State legislature.

The Tenth Schedule originally had two exceptions that would not render the members liable for disqualification viz., one-third of members of the 'legislature party' splitting to form a separate group (paragraph 3), or a merger of their 'political party' with another party that is approved by two-thirds of the members of its 'legislature party' (paragraph 4). However, considering the need to strengthen the 'anti-defection' law, paragraph 3 was omitted in 2003.

With the deletion of paragraph 3, there have been instances of two-third

members of a legislature party 'practically' defecting but claiming to be the original political party in order to escape disqualification. This happened in the case of Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party in June 2022 and July 2023 respectively.

There have also been instances where more than two-third members of a 'legislature party' in a house have merged themselves with another political party to escape disqualification. This happened in September 2019 (in Rajasthan) when all 6 Bahujan Samajwadi Party MLAs merged themselves with the Congress and in September 2022 (in Goa) when 8 out of the 11 Congress MLAs merged themselves with the BJP. The Bombay High Court upheld the merger of Goa's Congress Legislature Party with the BJP, though an appeal is pending in the apex court. A similar move occurred in April 2026 when 7 of 10 AAP Rajya Sabha MPs merged with the BJP.

What is the present case in Bengal?

After the recent West Bengal polls, around 60 of the 80 MLAs elected from Trinamool Congress formed a separate faction led by Ritabrata Banerjee, who was recognised as the Leader of Opposition in the State Assembly even after the party expelled him. Meanwhile, 20 of the 28 Lok Sabha MPs have submitted their decision to the Lok Sabha Speaker to merge themselves with the NCPI. Their claim is that they constitute two-thirds of the legislature party and are hence authorised to take this step under the provisions of the Tenth Schedule without attracting disqualification.

What may be way forward?

A plain reading of the Tenth Schedule allows only for merger of a political party with another party that is approved by two-thirds of its legislature party. It does not authorise two-thirds of the legislature party in a house to merge itself with another political party to claim immunity from defection. However, in the recent instance with respect to proposed merger of Trinamool Lok Sabha MPs with NCPI as well as the merger of Rajya Sabha MPs of AAP with the BJP, this is what has happened. It is also subject to interpretation whether a merger of an 'original political party' can happen only with another political party that already has members in the legislative house. Moreover, the authority to decide on the

disqualification of members is vested in the Speaker or Chairman. While they are expected to perform this constitutional role impartially, the presiding officers have often favoured the ruling dispensation. The Supreme Court in *K. M. Singh case in 2020*, recommended that the Parliament amend the Constitution to vest these powers in an independent tribunal headed by judges.

An authoritative Supreme Court judgement in the matters of merger and setting up of an independent tribunal to decide on disqualification may reduce the ambiguities surrounding the Tenth Schedule. However, it may not prevent the ingenious methods adopted by political parties to circumvent the Tenth Schedule. Any such manoeuvres may be viewed as a betrayal of the electorate by the elected representatives. A stricter measure, as recommended by the Law Commission in 1999, could be to amend the Tenth Schedule and delete paragraph 4 that provides exemption from disqualification for merger of political parties. Any action by elected members of a legislature party against their political party should lead to disqualification that results in seeking fresh mandate from the people.

Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified'. He currently trains at 'Officers IAS Academy'. Views expressed are personal.

Tenth Schedule and Anti-Defection Law — Key Concepts

• Origin and Purpose

- Defections in 1960s–70s caused political instability; the 52nd Constitutional Amendment (1985) inserted the Tenth Schedule.
- Provides for disqualification of members who voluntarily give up party membership or vote against party directions.
- Distinction: 'political party' = entire organisation; 'legislature party' = all elected members of a party in a House.

• Merger Provision (Paragraph 4)

- Original Tenth Schedule had two exceptions: splitting (Para 3) and merger (Para 4).
- Para 3 (split — one-third members) was deleted in 2003 to strengthen anti-defection.
- Para 4 (merger) survives: valid merger requires two-thirds of the legislature party to merge with another party.
- Merger must be of the 'political party', not just the 'legislature party' — a critical legal distinction.

• Misuse and Way Forward

- Post-2003, instances of two-thirds members 'merging' have been used to escape disqualification (Shiv Sena 2022, NCP 2023).
- Disqualification power vests in the Speaker/Chairman often accused of partisan functioning.
- Supreme Court in K.M. Singh case (2020) recommended an independent tribunal headed by judges.
- Law Commission (1999) recommended deleting Para 4; any merger should lead to disqualification requiring a fresh mandate.

Urban Water Crisis : Five Solutions for Indian Cities

Water-secure cities require a combination of clear and transparent emergency planning, systematic reduction of water losses through leak repairs, collective efforts to curb demand, strong safeguards to ensure water quality during shortages, and better management and reuse of wastewater

Manish Dubey
K.V. Santhosh Ragavan

Urban India's water emergency is no longer a future risk. It has become the normal of our summers. From high-rises anxiously tracking tanker schedules to informal settlements queuing at a single standpost, every year brings the same mix of dry taps, frayed tempers, and quiet resignation.

This summer, residents in parts of New Delhi have already faced days without piped water supply and large families have had to make do with just one 20-litre water can for a day. The Delhi Jal Board has reportedly planned to deploy more than 1,000 tankers to manage the crisis. Similar scenes have played out in other major cities, including Chennai, Bengaluru, and Hyderabad, over the last few summers.

Unfortunately, India still treats this as a seasonal inconvenience to endure until the clouds arrive.

Most cities source their water from reservoirs, groundwater or a combination of both. The annual summer water shortage however is the result of choices made over years. Cities have grown faster than their systems. Lakes and tanks have been built over. People are consuming groundwater faster than it can be replenished.

Cities often focus on finding new water sources instead of fixing and maintaining existing networks. Choices around

development planning and control, enforcement of groundwater regulations, water use and wastewater management, made by all – from every individual to service providers to policymakers – shape the experience each summer.

Many cities have moved from nearby rivers and lakes to distant sources and rapidly depleting groundwater, sinking more borewells and laying longer pipelines. What looks like a sudden shortage is often the result of this slow erosion of local buffers. At the same time, lakes, tanks, ponds and stormwater channels that once softened both floods and droughts have been encroached upon or converted, so a few hours of intense rain can flood streets and, a few weeks later, the same city is again queuing for tankers.

Beyond short-term coping

For many residents, especially in poorer settlements and smaller towns, the crisis is also about quality. Intermittent supply, leaky pipes, and unsafe storage mean that even when water arrives, it may not be safe to drink. The familiar scenes of tankers, angry protests, and frantic borewell drilling are therefore not one-offs. They are symptoms of a chronic condition that shows up in illness, lost workdays and mounting bills.

If we accept this, we will also realise that coping from week to week is no longer enough.

First, every city needs an honest and public emergency water plan. Residents

should not have to rely on rumours to know what is happening. A basic plan would identify the most vulnerable wards and critical facilities, set simple rules for how water will be prioritised when supplies are tight such as duration and frequency of supply to enable better tail end distribution, and commit to regular public updates on storage levels and expected supply. Where such information is shared clearly, it manages expectations and reduces grievances; this is less about technology than about treating information as part of the service.

Second, a concerted effort must be made to recover water that is already in the system but never reaches the taps. Instead of announcing distant, expensive new sources, cities can launch a time-bound 'leak hunt' in the worst-affected zones: walk key stretches of the network, fix visible leaks quickly, use simple tools to detect hidden ones, and set a short-term target for cutting losses. In systems where a large share – nearly 30% – of water is lost before it reaches users, even modest reductions in a few high-loss areas is equivalent to creating a new local source without building a new pipeline.

Third, government buildings, big campuses and commercial complexes are among the steadiest consumers of water. And a quick internal audit, basic leak repairs, and simple efficiency measures over the next month can free up meaningful volumes and set an example. Neighbourhoods and resident groups can

agree on clear norms for peak months, limiting non-essential uses, tracking weekly consumption and asking tanker suppliers where they draw their water from – while local leaders in low-income areas help authorities see how supply actually reaches their lanes.

Fourth, any emergency response must include water quality: rapid testing in high-risk neighbourhoods and tanker water supply, temporary support for basic treatment where problems are found, and simple communication about safe storage.

Finally, water security cannot be achieved without improving how we manage used-water. Measures to reduce leaks in water pipelines should also be used on sewer networks to identify and stop major sewage exfiltration and prevent contamination.

Not a single solution

Quick, low-cost upgrades to used-water treatment plants such as, optimising aeration, de-weeding, and desludging, can further reduce pollution and help augment available surface- and ground-water resources.

No single measure will pull Indian cities out of their water emergency. Together, however, they can directly address the summer's pain points: unpredictability, waste, inequity, and illness.

Manish Dubey is Dean & Rahul Bajaj Chair, School of Governance, Indian Institute for Human Settlements (IIHS). K.V. Santhosh Ragavan is Adjunct Faculty, IIHS.

India's Urban Water Crisis

• Nature of the Crisis

- Urban India's water emergency is structural, not seasonal : **result of over-extraction of groundwater, encroachment of water bodies, and ageing pipelines.**
- Cities rely on **distant rivers and lakes, depleting groundwater and laying longer pipelines.**
- **Nearly 30% of water is lost before reaching users due to leakages in distribution networks.**
- **Intermittent supply and unsafe storage make water unsafe even when it arrives.**

• Five Solutions

- 1. **Emergency Water Plan:** transparent, ward-level planning with public updates on storage, supply schedules, and tanker sources.
- 2. **Leak Hunt:** systematic network audit in worst-affected zones; fix leaks to recover existing supply without new sources.
- 3. **Demand-Side Management:** government buildings and commercial complexes to lead efficiency; local resident groups to enforce norms.
- 4. **Water Quality Response:** rapid testing in high-risk areas, temporary treatment support, clear communication on safe storage.
- 5. **Wastewater Reuse:** upgrade used-water treatment plants; use leak detection on sewer networks to prevent contamination.

• Governance Dimensions

- Chronic underfunding of water infrastructure and focus on new sources over fixing existing networks.
- Jal Jeevan Mission addresses rural supply; urban water governance remains fragmented.
- Recommendations align with 74th Amendment mandate for Urban Local Bodies to manage water.
- Integrated urban water management requires convergence of AMRUT, Smart Cities Mission, and local body capacity.

Thank you